



century in his maiden Test against India in Ahmedabad. A year later, England handed Stokes his ODI cap. Over the next 15 years, their careers unfolded in parallel.

The Kiwi, part of Martin Crowe's 'Fab Four' alongside Virat Kohli, Joe Root and Steve Smith, always felt different even among that elite company. There was no urge to get in the face of the opposition. His

batting carried the same personality as the man himself: cool, calm and composed.

He met the ball under his eyes, often making it seem as though he was late on it when, in reality, he simply had more time than everyone else. One of the signs of a great batter is how effortlessly they collect runs, and with Williamson, it often felt as though he had just walked in

Iconic knock: Ben Stokes celebrates his unbeaten 135 at Headingley in 2019, one of the defining performances of a career built around seizing cricket's biggest moments. REUTERS

before the scoreboard suddenly showed him in the 30s. His split grip, control and ability to find gaps even when the field was packed reflected a batter who could always find a way, no matter the ask.

For Williamson, though, runs were never possessions, only service. He once said, "The runs aren't yours; they're of service for the team." That line perhaps best summed up his career. He finished with 48 international hundreds and 19,346 runs: a body of work built for the team.

Stokes, meanwhile, was more about moments, earning what the current internet generation would call "aura points."

The high backlift, exaggerated trigger movements and clearing of the front leg gave the sense that every ball could produce something outrageous or reckless, sometimes even both. He batted as if he wanted to bend the game to his will, and often did.

He did the same with the ball in his hand. Stokes, England's golden arm, had a habit of making things happen, whether through long spells or improbable breakthroughs.

One of the moments that captured him best came right after the Trent Bridge crowd learned of his retirement. Into his 11th over of the spell, he charged in once the applause had settled and had New Zealand's Zak Foulkes caught in the slips. The roar around Nottingham swelled again as he leapt into the air to celebrate a dismissal he would cherish for a long time.

Stokes finished with 7,273 Test runs and 252 wickets in Tests, becoming only the second player after South Africa's Jacques Kallis to complete the double of 7,000-plus runs and 250-plus wickets.

His ODI career, however, remains a big what-if. For all the off-field interruptions, Stokes still gave England some of its greatest



Format	M	Runs	Best	100s	50s	Avg.	Wkts	Best	5w
Tests	122	7273	258	14	37	34.46	252	6/22	6
ODIs	114	3463	182	5	24	41.22	74	5/61	1

T20Is	M	Runs	Best	S/R	Avg.	Wkts	Best
	43	585	52*	128	21.66	26	3/26

Captaincy record

Format	M	W	L	D
Tests	44	24	18	2
ODIs	3	3	—	—

BEN STOKES